

Buckingham Palace - Kids

UK Family Tour

The King Who Isn't the Boss

Here is something strange and completely true. You are looking at the house of a real, live king, King Charles the Third. He wears a crown made of gold and sparkling jewels. Soldiers stand guard at his gate. His face is printed on every single coin in the whole country. You would think a king like that gets to decide absolutely everything, wouldn't you? Tell everybody what to do, make all the rules, boss the entire country around.

But here is the twist. He doesn't. Not really.

In Britain, the king is the most famous, most important, most dressed up person in the land. When he arrives, people bow and cheer and wave flags. But he is not the one who actually makes the rules. The rules get made somewhere else, in an enormous building full of people who argue all day long, about a mile from where you are standing. It is called Parliament, and we are going to walk right past it later. The people inside are chosen by ordinary grown ups, in a vote, and their leader is called the prime minister.

So think of it like this. The king reigns, which means he is the head of the country and everyone treats him like the star of the show. But he does not rule, which would mean bossing everyone around and making the laws. Those are two totally different jobs, and clever old Britain gives them to two different places.

Why would a country do something so odd? Because of a very long, very bumpy story, hundreds of years of kings slowly having to give away their power, sometimes because they were forced to. And today, lucky you, we get to walk straight through both halves of it. Right here, the shiny crown part, with the palace and the guards and the gold. Over at Westminster, the real power part. And then, deep underground, a secret bunker where the whole country was once in terrible danger. Ready? Let's go.

So What Does a King Even Do?

If the king doesn't make the rules, you might be wondering, well, what does he actually do all day? Sit around eating cake off golden plates? Not quite. His job is enormous, and busy, and it is all about being the star of the country rather than the boss of it.

Here is one of his real jobs, and it is a funny one. Every single new law that Parliament makes has to be shown to the king, and he has to say yes to it before it can happen. Sounds powerful, right? But here is the catch. He always says yes. Always. No king has said no for more than three hundred years, because everyone agrees that saying no would break the whole deal. So he does have to sign, and he also has to sign. Both things are true at once. Funny, isn't it?

Once a year he does something amazing. He climbs into a golden coach, pulled by horses, wears a crown so heavy it could give you a headache, and rides to Parliament to read out a big list of all the new laws for the year. But get this. He didn't write a single word of it. The government wrote it, and he just reads it out loud, like a newsreader in a crown.

The rest of the time, he does the things only a king can do. Once a week he has a private chat with the prime minister, where he is allowed to give advice but never allowed to give orders. He hands out shiny medals to brave people and clever people and even famous singers. He welcomes kings and presidents from other countries. He visits hospitals and plants trees and waves, so much waving.

And then there is the pure sparkly showing off, and honestly it is the best part. The soldiers in bright red coats and enormous fuzzy black hats. The Changing of the Guard. The family stepping out onto that balcony while a huge crowd roars below. None of it makes a single rule. But all of it says, loud and proud, this is our country, and it has been here a very, very long time.

How Kings Stopped Being the Boss

Long, long ago, a king really was the boss of everything. His word was the law. He grabbed the money, he started the wars, and if you complained, well, too bad for you. So how did we get from that all powerful king to the king across these railings, who is famous and grand but doesn't really rule at all? It took about eight hundred years and three enormous, dramatic moments. Here they are.

The first happened in a grassy meadow by a river, way back in the year twelve fifteen. There was a king named John, and honestly, almost nobody liked him. He kept losing wars and demanding more and more money. Finally his most powerful lords had had enough. They put on their armour, cornered him, and made him press his seal onto a document we now call Magna Carta, which means the Great Charter. And it said something jaw dropping for the time. Even the king has to obey the law. He couldn't just steal your stuff or throw you in a dungeon whenever he felt like it. That one idea never went away.

The second moment was much scarier, so brace yourself. About four hundred years later, a king named Charles the First had a gigantic argument with Parliament about who was really in charge. The argument grew and grew until it turned into an actual war, king against Parliament. And Parliament won. Then, in sixteen forty nine, they did something almost nobody had ever dared do to a king. They put him on trial, found him guilty, and chopped off his head. For about eleven years, Britain had no king at all. Later they did bring a king back, but every king after that knew the terrifying lesson. Do not push Parliament too far.

The third change was the slowest and the quietest. Bit by bit, over hundreds of years, more and more ordinary people were allowed to vote, until nearly every grown up in the country got a say. And as the people got more power, the king got less and less, until the crown became what you see today. Loved by lots of people, dazzling to look at, and in charge of almost nothing. Pretty wild for a story that started with an angry king in a field, don't you think?

Your Spotting Game for Today

Now you know the big secret, that the king reigns but Parliament rules, the whole day turns into a kind of treasure hunt. Here are the things to spot, and what each one is really telling you.

Start right here at the palace, because this is all about the crown, the sparkly, showing off side of the story. Look up at that balcony in the middle. That is where the royal family comes out to be seen by gigantic crowds on the biggest days, a coronation, a royal wedding, a huge celebration. The whole point is simply to be seen. Look at the guards in their bright red coats and their tall furry hats. They are real soldiers, but their job here is to look magnificent and keep a tradition alive that is hundreds of years old. This whole place is saying the same thing over and over. We have always been here. We are still here.

Then, as we head toward Westminster, watch everything change. You will see a gigantic clock tower most people call Big Ben, standing over the Houses of Parliament. That building, not this palace, is where the real arguing and deciding happens. And nearby, on a street called Whitehall, keep your eyes peeled for a

plain black door with the number ten on it. That is where the prime minister lives and works, the person who actually runs the country. No golden coach. No balcony. No fuzzy hats. Just a very important black door. That difference, between the dazzling palace and the plain busy doors, is the whole secret standing right in front of you.

And then we go underground, into the Churchill War Rooms, where the story suddenly gets deadly serious. Because a long time ago, in nineteen forty, this whole clever arrangement, the crown, the Parliament, the freedom to argue about anything at all, very nearly got destroyed by a terrible war. A small group of brave people hid in a cramped secret bunker and helped save it. So as we walk today, keep score. The gold and the guards this morning, the doors of power this afternoon, and the bunker at the end. They are all pieces of one big question that Britain spent eight hundred years trying to answer. Who gets to be in charge, and how do you stop them from being too much in charge?

The Palace That Started as a Big House

Look straight ahead, through the tall iron railings. That huge stone building with the balcony in the middle is Buckingham Palace, the London home of the King. It is one of the most famous houses in the whole world. But here is a secret. It did not begin as a palace at all. It began as an ordinary big house.

More than three hundred years ago, in the year seventeen oh three, a rich man called the Duke of Buckingham built himself a grand town house right here. People called it Buckingham House, after him. It was smart and handsome, but it was nothing like the giant palace you are looking at now.

Then, in seventeen sixty one, a king named George the Third bought the house. He did not buy it to show off. He bought it as a cosy family home for his wife, Queen Charlotte, and their children. People even called it the Queen's House. Imagine that, a queen with her own house full of children, right where the King now lives.

Years later, a king called George the Fourth had a big idea. He did not want a house any more. He wanted a palace, with golden rooms and grand staircases. So he hired a clever architect named John Nash to make it enormous and beautiful. And slowly, wing by wing, the house grew into a palace.

But no king or queen actually lived here as their main home until a young woman came along. Her name was Queen Victoria, and in eighteen thirty seven, when she was just eighteen years old, she moved in. She was the very first ruler to make Buckingham Palace her home. Ever since then, it has been the palace of kings and queens.

Now look again at that balcony in the middle. On special days, the royal family steps out onto it and waves to enormous crowds down below. We will hear more about that balcony soon.

It is about ten o'clock in the morning, and it is a Thursday. You might have hoped to see the guards in red coats swapping over, which is called the Changing of the Guard. But it does not happen today. It only happens on some days, like Monday, Wednesday and Friday. Do not worry. A bit later, on a street called Whitehall, we will meet soldiers on horseback instead, sitting perfectly still on their horses.

For now, stand in the sunshine by the railings, and let me tell you the palace's stories.

A House, a King, and Fifteen Children

Let us go back to the very beginning, to the year seventeen oh three. Close your eyes and picture this same spot with no palace at all. Instead, there is a tall brick house with big windows, built for a rich duke. It had gardens and grand rooms, and the duke was very proud of it.

But houses get passed on. Many years later, in seventeen sixty one, King George the Third came to look at it. He liked it very much, and he bought the whole house for twenty one thousand pounds. Back then, that was a giant pile of money.

Here is the surprising part. The King did not want it for parties, or for showing off to important visitors. He wanted a warm, private home for his family. So the palace of today actually started its royal life as something rather cosy.

The King gave the house to his wife, Queen Charlotte. People started calling it the Queen's House, because it was really hers. And oh, it was busy. King George and Queen Charlotte had fifteen children. Fifteen! Almost all of them were born right here, in the rooms behind those railings. Imagine the noise, the running feet, the crying babies, and the toys everywhere.

King George loved two things especially, books and clocks. He filled the house with thousands of books, so many that whole rooms became libraries. And he loved clocks that ticked and chimed and told the time in clever ways. If you had walked past his door, you might have heard dozens of clocks all ticking at once.

So the building was not born grand and golden. It was born as a family home, full of children and books and the tick tick tick of clocks. The palace you see today is like that first house, but wearing a much fancier coat, which we will talk about later.

Keep that picture in your head, a real family living here, long before the crowds and the flags and the famous balcony. Everything huge starts somewhere small.

The King Who Wanted a Palace

King George the Third's son grew up to become King George the Fourth, and he had very grand taste. He did not want to live in a plain house. He wanted a palace fit for a king, with marble and gold and rooms that made visitors gasp.

So he found a famous architect called John Nash and told him, make it magnificent. Nash got to work, adding great wings and columns and beautiful ceilings. There was just one problem. It cost a fortune, far more than anyone had agreed to spend. The bills grew and grew. In the end, poor Nash lost his job because the palace was costing so much money.

Another architect, Edward Blore, was brought in to finish things off more carefully. But sadly, King George the Fourth died before the palace was ready. He never got to live in the home he had dreamed of.

So who was the first ruler to truly live here? A young woman. Her name was Victoria, and in eighteen thirty seven, only a few weeks after she became queen, she moved in. She was just eighteen years old. Picture her arriving with her boxes and her little dog, the first monarch ever to call this enormous place home.

Victoria soon found the palace had problems. Some chimneys smoked, some doors would not shut properly, and it could be draughty and cold. But she stayed, and she made it the heart of the royal family, and every king and queen since has lived here too.

Now look up at that balcony in the middle of the building. Queen Victoria was the first to step out onto it and wave to the crowds, at a great celebration in her time. Ever since, on the biggest days, the royal family walks out onto that very balcony. They wave, the crowds cheer, and sometimes aeroplanes roar overhead in a long line. If you visit London on a truly special day, that little stone platform is where every camera in the country will be pointing.

One king wanted a palace. One young queen turned it into a home. And that is how a house became the most famous address in Britain.

Bombs, Bravery, and a Very Busy Palace

Now for a braver, more serious story. Long ago, during the Second World War, enemy planes flew over London at night and dropped bombs on the city. This frightening time was called the Blitz. Night after night, families hid and hoped their homes would still be standing in the morning.

You might think the King and Queen would run far away to somewhere safe. They did not. King George the Sixth and his wife, Queen Elizabeth, chose to stay right here in the palace, in the same danger as everyone else in London.

And the danger was real. In September nineteen forty, bombs actually fell on Buckingham Palace itself. One of them destroyed the palace chapel. The King and Queen were inside the building when it happened,

and they felt the whole place shake. Over the course of the whole war, the palace was hit not once but many times.

But here is the part people never forgot. Some of the poorest parts of London, in the east of the city, were being bombed terribly. After the palace was hit too, Queen Elizabeth said something that people repeated for years and years. She said she was almost glad, because now she could look the East End in the face. What she meant was, now we are all in this together. We are suffering the same as everybody else.

That small, brave sentence made people love her. The royal family had stayed, and shared the fear, and that really mattered.

Today the palace is calm and busy in a much happier way. It is not just a home. It is like a giant office for the King and the whole monarchy, with hundreds of people working inside. There are grand parties in the garden, important visitors from all around the world, and shiny medals given out for people who have done something special.

And here is some lucky news for us. In the summer, for a few weeks only, the palace opens some of its most magnificent rooms so that ordinary people can walk through them. Right now, this very summer, those rooms are open. Just behind these walls, visitors are gazing up at golden ceilings and enormous chandeliers, in the real rooms of a real royal palace.

How to Read a Palace

Stand still for a moment and really look at the front of Buckingham Palace. It is long and grand and pale grey, with rows and rows of windows, and a fence of tall black and gold railings keeping everyone at a polite distance. It is a hot, sunny day, a proper heatwave, so find a spot by the railings near the big white statue, and let your eyes do some exploring.

First, look at the giant white monument right in front of you. That is the Victoria Memorial, built to remember Queen Victoria. Look at the very top and you will see a golden figure shining in the sun, with wings, like an angel of victory. We will look at her more closely soon.

Now, the front of the palace. Count the floors, and spot the balcony right in the middle. That balcony is famous all over the world. On special days the royal family stands there and waves.

Here is a brilliant trick. Look up at the flagpole on the roof. There is always a flag flying, but which one? If you can see a colourful flag with lions and a harp on it, that is the Royal Standard, and it means the King himself is at home inside right now. If instead you see the red, white and blue Union Flag, it means the King is away somewhere else. So the flag is like a secret message, telling everyone whether the King is in.

The palace is much, much bigger than it looks from here, because you are only seeing the front. It has seven hundred and seventy five rooms. Seventy eight of them are just bathrooms. And behind the building, where you cannot see, there is an enormous secret garden, so big you could fit dozens of football pitches inside it.

Remember, today is Thursday, so there is no Changing of the Guard, no marching band, no red coats swapping over. But that gives us plenty of time to just stand and look. A palace like this is full of clues and stories, if you know how to read it. So let us read it together, piece by piece, starting with what all this stone is really made of.

The Palace That Changed Its Clothes

Here is something amazing about the building in front of you. It is a bit like an onion, with layer built on top of layer. Three different architects, in three different times, each added their part. So the palace has changed its clothes more than once.

Deep inside is the oldest part, from the grand rebuild by John Nash, the architect we met earlier. He built tall wings that reached forward like arms, with an open courtyard in the middle, a bit like a giant letter U.

But there was a problem. The royal family kept growing, and they needed more space and more privacy. So another architect, Edward Blore, closed off the open end of that U. He built a whole new front across it, the side that faces you right now, turning the U into a closed square with a hidden courtyard inside. That is why you cannot see into the middle. There is a secret courtyard behind that wall.

Now here is the most surprising part of all. The stone front you are looking at is not very old at all. In nineteen thirteen, the palace front had become worn and grubby from all the smoke in the London air, so they decided to give it a brand new face in pale, clean stone called Portland stone.

And how long do you think it took to rebuild the whole front of a palace? Years? No. They did it in about thirteen weeks, which is roughly three months. They waited until the royal family went away on their summer holiday, then hundreds of workers swarmed all over the front and rebuilt it super fast, so it

would be finished by the time everyone came home. Imagine coming back from your holiday to find your house had a whole new face.

So when you look at the palace, remember you are really seeing three buildings in one. An old heart by Nash, a front added by Blore, and a fresh stone face fitted in one speedy summer. Same palace, three coats, each one hiding another underneath.

The Golden Lady and the Giant House

Let us look closer at that huge white monument in front of the gates. This is the Victoria Memorial, made to remember Queen Victoria after she died. A sculptor named Thomas Brock carved it, and it was shown to the public in nineteen eleven.

Look at the seated marble lady facing down the long road. That is Victoria herself, carved in gleaming white marble, looking out over her city forever. Around her are other stone figures that stand for things people admired, like being brave and being kind and being truthful.

Now look right up to the very top. See that golden figure with wings, glinting in the sunshine? She is Victory, covered in real gold so that she shines on even the greyest London day. Some people say the whole monument looks like an enormous wedding cake, white and grand, with a golden decoration on top. Once you see the wedding cake, you can never unsee it.

Now, back to the palace, and get ready to be amazed by its size. Remember, it has seven hundred and seventy five rooms. If you slept in a different bedroom every single night, it would take you months to try them all. There are seventy eight bathrooms. There is a swimming pool, a cinema for watching films, a doctor's room, and even its own little post office, all hidden inside.

And behind the palace lies its greatest secret, a garden of thirty nine acres. That makes it the biggest private garden in the whole of London. It has a lake with birds on it, more than a thousand trees, and even a tennis court. Every summer the King invites thousands of guests there for garden parties, with tea and cake on the royal lawn.

So next time someone says Buckingham Palace is just a big house, you will know the truth. A golden angel on a marble cake out front, hundreds of rooms inside, and a secret park behind. It is not a house at all. It is a whole little world, hiding behind these railings, right in the middle of the busy city.

The King Keeps Moving House

Here is a puzzle to carry with you all the way through our holiday. Where does the King really live? You are looking at the answer right now, through these railings. Buckingham Palace. But here is the surprising part. Kings and queens have only lived here for a fairly short time. For hundreds and hundreds of years before that, they lived somewhere else. And they kept moving. Like a family that keeps packing up its boxes and moving to a new house, the crown moved right across London, one home at a time, for almost a thousand years.

Let us follow the moves, because they join up nearly everywhere we go.

It all began where we began, on Monday. The very first royal home was the Tower of London, that mighty stone castle down by the river. Kings really lived inside it, long, long ago. We will find out soon why they left.

Next, the king moved to a place called Westminster, right next to the big church where kings get crowned. You will see the spot later today, because that is where Big Ben and the Houses of Parliament stand now. A king lived there for hundreds of years, until a big fire burned the royal rooms.

So the king moved again, just up the road, to a palace called Whitehall. And listen to this. Whitehall grew into the biggest palace in all of Europe, with more than a thousand rooms. But one terrible night, it burned down too, nearly all of it. You will walk right past where it stood this afternoon. Only one single building lived through the fire, and it is still standing there today.

After that, the king moved to St James's Palace, a red brick palace right beside the park we are about to walk through. And here is something funny. Even now, that older palace is still counted as the most important one of all, more important on paper than this giant here.

And then, at last, a young queen named Victoria moved into Buckingham Palace, and kings and queens have lived here ever since.

So there is the puzzle solved. Five homes. Tower, Westminster, Whitehall, St James's, and here. Let me tell you more about each one.

Related listening: The royal address story starts at the Tower, the Conqueror's first London stronghold. Listen back — "The White Tower: 950 Years Old" (Tower of London, Day 3).

Related listening: Next stop on the royal-homes trail: Henry the Eighth's great palace at Hampton Court. Coming up — "The Palace a King Took for Himself" (Hampton Court Palace, Day 7).

Why the Kings Left the Tower

Do you remember Monday morning, at the Tower of London, with the ravens, and the shining Crown Jewels, and the guards in their funny hats? That castle is where our whole story begins, so let us go back there for a minute.

A very long time ago, a king called William the Conqueror built the tall white tower in the middle of it. He built it to do two jobs at once. It was a fort, strong enough to keep his enemies out, and it was a home, grand enough for a king to live in. Clever, right? Two things in one. For hundreds of years, kings really did live inside those walls.

But think about it for a second. Would you want to live in a cold, dark castle, with thick stone walls and hardly any windows? The kings slowly started to feel the same way. Bit by bit, they decided they would

rather live somewhere comfier and roomier. So they moved out. The very last king to sleep there, long ago, was a king called James, and after him, no king or queen ever lived in the Tower again.

So what did the Tower turn into instead? Exactly the amazing place you saw on Monday. It became the safest strongbox in the whole country. It kept the king's gold, and his weapons, and once even a zoo full of wild animals, with lions and a real polar bear. It became a prison for the most dangerous prisoners of all. And best of all, it became the home of the Crown Jewels, those dazzling golden crowns and that giant sparkling diamond you saw behind the glass. They are still kept there today.

And those guards you spotted, the ones called Beefeaters? They are what is left of the king's very own bodyguard, from back when a real king lived inside. The king went away, but his guards stayed. They are still there, guarding his treasure, hundreds of years later.

So the cold stone you touched on Monday was the crown's very first home, the place this whole long adventure first began.

More Palaces Coming Up

Here is the exciting part. Our royal home story is not finished, because on this holiday you are going to visit more of them. So keep your eyes open.

Tomorrow you are off to Hampton Court, a giant palace beside the river that belonged to King Henry the Eighth. Henry had lots and lots of houses, more than sixty of them, but this one was his absolute favourite. He filled it with feasts and games and beautiful gardens. It was like an enormous fun palace for a king. But it was a bit too far from the middle of London to ever become the main home, so it always stayed a special treat. When you go, look really carefully, because Hampton Court is actually two palaces stuck together, an old one and a newer one, built by two different kings hundreds of years apart. See if you can spot the place where one stops and the other begins.

And here is something that lots of people forget. The King is not only King of England. He is King of Scotland too. So Scotland has its own royal homes, and you will see them next week. In a city called Edinburgh, there is a huge castle sitting right on top of an old volcano, and at the other end of the street, a beautiful palace called Holyroodhouse. That palace is still the King's home in Scotland today. He goes and stays there every summer. Later on you will visit another mighty castle called Stirling, sitting high on its own rock, where Scottish kings and queens were crowned and grew up when they were children, maybe about your age. So the King really has homes in two whole countries at once, an English home and a Scottish home, and you are going to see both of them.

So here is a game to play as we travel. Count the royal homes. The King does not have just one house. He has a whole collection of them, castles and palaces, and enough for two whole countries. Every single castle and palace we visit is one more home belonging to the very same royal family.

Is It a Palace or a Castle?

Here is a brilliant question that even grown-ups get muddled by. Why are some royal homes called castles, and some called palaces? What is the actual difference?

It is really quite simple, and once you know it, you can spot it every time. A castle was built to be strong, so that soldiers could defend it in a battle. Castles have thick walls, tall towers, and they usually sit up high, so you can see the enemy coming from far away. A palace was built for something completely different. It was built to be beautiful and comfy, to show off how rich and important the king was. No battle walls at all, just grand rooms and lovely gardens. So the Tower of London is a castle. Buckingham Palace, where you are standing right now, is a palace. The name tells you what it was really made for.

But there is one amazing home that breaks the rule. It is called Windsor Castle, and it is not far from London. It started life as a proper fort, built to guard the city, so it truly is a castle. But kings and queens have lived in it, without ever stopping, for almost a thousand years, longer than any other home in the whole world. So it is a castle that is also cosy. A fort that is also a family house. Pretty special, isn't it?

There are two little ones too. There is Kensington Palace, where Queen Victoria was born, before she came to live here. And there is Kew Palace, the smallest royal palace of all, a little red brick house tucked away in a garden.

So now you know the biggest secret of the whole trip. The King has never had just one home. He has loads of them, big ones and little ones, forts and palaces, in two different countries, each one from a different time long ago. And Buckingham Palace, right in front of you, is simply the one where the story finally stopped moving. So next time someone asks you where the King lives, you can smile, because you know the real answer is almost a thousand years long.